Liberal Democracy

Democratic government that provides for the protection of individual human rights, in order to prevent a majority from oppressing a minority.

Liberalism

Advocacy of positive government action to improve the welfare of individuals, support for civil rights, and tolerance for political and social change.

Limited Government

A government whose powers are limited, particularly by institutional checks.

Presidential System

Representative democracy where political power is vested in separately elected and appointed branches of national government. This system is used in the USA.

Representative Democracy

A form of government in which representatives are elected by the people to make and enforce laws and policies. Political decisions are made by the officials elected by the people. [Some such democracies retain a monarchy in a ceremonial role.]

Republic

A form of government in which sovereignty rests with the people (or a portion of the people), as opposed to a king or monarch or dictator. This form of Representative Democracy was created by the framers of the US constituion.

Separation of Powers

The division of governmental functions and powers among different branches of government, so that the various self-interests of each group would moderate those of the others.

Theocracy. [From Greek theos = god and krateein = to rule.]

Rule by a god, which in practice means rule by a priesthood. No separation of church and state. Compare with aristocracy.

Totalitarian

A regime of command by the government and obedience by the citizens. The regime controls all aspects of political and social life (as in George Orwell's 1984). In contrast with an authoritarian state, all social and economic institutions are under government control.

Unicameral Legislature

A legislature that comprises a single part or chamber. In the USA (early 21st century) only the state of Nebraska has a unicameral legislature. Compare with bicameral legislature.

Universal Suffrage. [From Latin suffragium = voting tablet, vote.] The right and privilege of all adults to vote for their representatives.

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